Procedural Representation and Elite Backlash: Experiences of Everyday Discrimination Faced by Scheduled Caste Village Presidents in India

Abstract:

When India's 73rd Constitutional Amendment took effect, Scheduled Castes were elected to village leadership positions in unprecedented numbers. However, procedural representation does not simply translate into substantive empowerment, as SC leaders encounter dynamic resistance aimed to undermine their de facto authority. In this article, I investigate how SC village presidents in Bihar, India experience and perceive backlash while exercising genuine constitutional authority. This study draws on semi-structured, in-depth interviews with three SC mukhiyas who have resisted traditional proxy leadership arrangements. The findings reveal that: (1) formal procedural representation often fails to generate substantive authority, and (2) independent SC leaders who resist proxy status face a multi-dimensional backlash – ranging from systematic bureaucratic obstruction to social microaggressions and the physical destruction of symbolic icons. This research highlights the systematic ways substantive democracy is undermined through everyday exclusion and the necessity of transforming underlying power structures alongside institutional reforms.

Keywords: Political Reservation, Caste, Local Governance, Backlash, India

Figure 1: Thematic Analysis Map